

What Is Existence?

Author: AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan.org - a group of people studying Madhyasth Darshan philosophy. Source repository: [raghavamohan/AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan](https://github.com/raghavamohan/AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan).

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The question: What is Existence? What exists? Does the thing that exists begin at some time?

This study reviews these questions from the standpoint of **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), then compares its answer with **Advaita Vedanta** and selected **modern philosophical approaches** to physical reality, consciousness, and selfhood.

Quick Glossary

Term	Plain meaning
Existence (<i>astitva</i>)	In Madhyasth Darshan: beingness (<i>hona</i>) and indestructibility (<i>anashita</i>), always present as coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>).
Coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>)	Reality as Omnipresence (<i>satta</i>) and all units (<i>ikai</i>) inseparably present together.
Omnipresence / Omnipotence / Space / Brahma / Satta	The all-pervasive, formless, non-transforming reality in which all units (<i>ikai</i>) are saturated (<i>samprikt</i> — submerged, soaked, surrounded: <i>dooba</i> , <i>bheega</i> , <i>gira</i>). The published translation's primary term is <i>Omnipotence</i> (used interchangeably here with <i>Omnipresence</i>); the source also names it Uniform/Equilibrium Energy, Space (<i>akasha</i>), Knowledge (<i>gyan</i>), Consciousness, God, and Absolute Energy. "Consciousness" here is one name for this pervasive reality and should not be read as a knowing subject — sentience (<i>chaitanya</i>) proper belongs to the sentient unit (<i>jeevan</i>).
Unit (<i>ikai</i>)	A countable, bounded entity in nature, whether insentient (<i>jada</i>) or sentient (<i>chaitanya</i>).
Jeevan (Sentient Self)	The sentient self: a real, immortal, constitutionally complete unit (<i>gathanpurna parmanu</i>) that works through the body (<i>shareer</i>).
Jada / Chaitanya (Insentient / Sentient)	Insentient and sentient nature (<i>prakriti</i>).
Atman / *Brahman*	In Advaita Vedanta: the Self and the one ultimate reality, finally identical.

Term	Plain meaning
Mithya	In Advaita: the world as dependent appearance, neither absolutely real nor sheer non-being.
Sat-Chit-Ananda	In Advaita: the threefold nature of Brahman / the true Self — being (<i>sat</i>), consciousness (<i>chit</i>), bliss (<i>ananda</i>).
Physicalism	The modern view that every real concrete phenomenon is physical.
Panpsychism	The view that experientiality belongs, at least in primitive form, to fundamental physical reality.
Illusionism	The view that phenomenal consciousness, as philosophers usually conceive it, is an illusion or misdescription.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

The claim in one sentence: Existence (*astitva*) is the eternally present coexistence (*saha-astitva*) of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and countless sentient (*chaitanya*) and insentient (*jada*) units (*ikai*) saturated (*samprikt*) in it; what exists never arises from non-existence (*abhava*) and is never annihilated, though units undergo motion, transformation, development, and awakening.

1.1 The Coexistential Structure: Space (*Satta*) and Nature (*Prakriti*)

Madhyasth Darshan does not define existence (*astitva*) as an object among objects, nor as a mental category imposed by a knower. It defines existence as the inseparable presentness of formless **Omnipresence** (*satta*) and formful **nature** (*prakriti*).

SB gives the most compressed formulation:

“What is evident is that consciousness and matter are inseparably present. Upon examining their fundamental nature, we learn that all of existence is essentially nature (matter) saturated in Omnipotence (consciousness). Here, ‘seeing’ is intended in the sense of understanding. Since nature saturated in Omnipotence is inseparably present, existence itself is eternally manifest in the form of coexistence.” - SB, p. 48

A note on the word “consciousness” in the translation. The published translation lists several names for this pervasive reality (*Satta / Vyapak*): Uniform Energy, Space (*akasha*), Knowledge (*gyan*), Consciousness, Omnipresence, Eternity, God, and Absolute Energy. The parenthetical “(consciousness)” therefore labels the all-pervasive reality, not a personal knowing mind. Sentience as the activity of a knower (*chaitanya*) is the status of *jeevan* (the

sentient unit), not of Omnipresence (*satta*) itself. Keeping these distinct is essential: Space is the pervasive ground in which units (*ikai*) are saturated (*samprikt*); sentience is not a property of that ground but of constitutionally complete units (*gathanpurna parmanu*).

The same passage immediately rejects two familiar origin stories:

1. Matter (*jada*) does not arise from consciousness/omnipresence (*satta*).
2. Consciousness/omnipresence (*satta*) does not arise from matter (*jada*).

Madhyasth Darshan's alternative is not creation of one from the other, but **inseparable presentness**. This coexistential ontology is expressed in the language of "Realisation Knowledge" (*anubhav jnan*):

"Sentient and insentient nature saturated in Omnipotence. The countless sentient and insentient units are saturated in Omnipotence (Omnipresence)." - MVD, p. 11

"All units saturated in the Omnipresence (permeative and transparent) have form, properties, essential nature & dharma, and have inherent orderliness & participate in overall orderliness." - MVD, p. 11

Existence thus has two inseparable aspects:

1. **Space (*Satta* / *Vyapak*):** The formless, all-pervasive, non-transforming, immeasurable reality. Space is **actionless energy** (*kriya-shunya urja*). While it does not perform actions, its permeative presence is the energy ground in which nature is energized, regulated, and conserved.

"Omnipotence is not confined within any dimension of length or breadth, nor can any measure be established for it; therefore, Omnipotence is all-pervasive." - SB, p. 49

"Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence. This itself is referred to as Space." - MVD, p. 35

2. **Units of Nature (*Ikai*):** The formful, active, countable, and bounded entities. Units are not illusions in Space; they have determinate reality and remain surrounded, submerged, and soaked in it.

"Nature, saturated in Omnipotence, exists as countless units. Each unit, being saturated in Omnipotence, remains surrounded, submerged, and soaked in it." - SB, p. 48

1.2 The Ontological Orders and Realist Relations of Nature

Nature (*prakriti*) does not exist as an amorphous mass, but as countless physical (*jada*) and sentient (*chaitanya*) units.

“Existence is not just physicochemical matter, but all physical, chemical and jeevan entities are inseparably present in Omnipresence.” - MVD, *The Alternative*, point 7

This is why the human being is understood as a joint form of a physical body (*shareer*) and a sentient self (*jeevan*):

“Brahma (Omnipotence) is omnipresent, and jeevan-clouds are many.” - MVD, p. 13

“The grandeur of humans as a joint form of jeevan and body.” - MVD, p. 13

Nature is organized into four real, objective **Ontological Orders** (*chaar avastha*), each defined by its unique innateness and purpose (*dharma*):

1. **Material Order (*Padarth Avastha*):** Bounded physical and chemical units (atoms, molecules, rocks). Its dharma is bare existence (*astitva / hona*).
2. **Pranic / Bio Order (*Pran Avastha*):** Organic cells, plants, and vegetation. Its dharma is growth and biological propagation (*pushti / dharana*).
3. **Animal Order (*Jeev Avastha*):** Animals (body + *jeevan*). Its dharma is the expectation of alive-ness (*jeene ki aasha*).
4. **Knowledge / Human Order (*Gyan Avastha*):** Humans (body + *jeevan*). Its dharma is the expectation of continuous happiness and right-living (*sukh-dharmita*).

These orders represent a real, progressive evolutionary hierarchy of development (*vikas*) within eternal coexistence. Because existence is coexistence, units do not exist in isolation. Every unit exists in an objective relation of complementarity (*poorakata*) and orderliness (*vyavastha*) with other units:

“Since existence is coexistence, complementarity and mutual recognition are eternally established.” - SB, p. 49

Relations (*sambandh*) and values (*mulya*) are therefore **ontologically real and perpetual** structural aspects of coexistence. In the human order, values like trust (*vishvas*), respect (*samman*), and gratitude (*kritagyata*) are the objective recognition and fulfilment of these existential relations. Unlike physicalism (which treats values as brain-model

projections) or Advaita (which treats relations as provisional appearances or *mithya*), Madhyasth Darshan grounds ethical values in the actual structure of existence.

1.3 Does Existence Begin? Time (*Kaal*) and Conservation

For Madhyasth Darshan, existence does not begin in the sense of coming from absolute non-existence (*abhava*). What exists has always existed, though its form, configuration, and states are in constant flux:

“That which exists continues to be, and that which was not, does not come into existence. Therefore, existence will remain as it is till eternity.” - SB, p. 49

“Nothing arrives at birth nor does anything depart with death. All that is, exists forever.” - JV, p. 20

To clarify this beginningless ontology, we must look at the nature of **Time** (*kaal*). Time is not an independent cosmic dimension or background substance. It is defined as the human measurement of the activity, change, and motion (*kriya / gati*) of units. Because formless Space (*satta*) is actionless and non-transforming, it is timeless. Time only applies to the transformations of active units in nature (*prakriti*).

This ontology distinguishes absolute annihilation (*vinasha*) from physical transformation (*roopantaran*). An entity may change its configuration, but its underlying substance (*vastu*) is never destroyed:

“A piece of charcoal continues to exist in other forms even after burning it.” - JV, p. 20

“At the fundamental level, a ‘reality’ never gets annihilated.” - JV, p. 20

The result is a strong, conservation-based ontology:

1. **Existence (*astitva*) as coexistence (*saha-astitva*) is beginningless and endless.**
2. **Omnipresence (*satta*) does not begin, change, or end.**
3. **Units (*ikai*) do not arise from non-being (*abhava*) and do not vanish into non-being.**
4. **Particular bodies (*shareer*), configurations, relations, and states do begin and end.**
5. **Development (*vikas*) and awakening (*jagriti*) are real, but they are not creation out of nothing.**

1.4 Development and Awakening without Creation from Nothing

While Madhyasth Darshan rejects creation from nothing, it provides a developmental account of how an atom (*parmanu*) reaches sentient status (*chaitanya*). This is the transition to constitutional completeness (*gathanpurnata*), forming the immortal sentient self (*jeevan*):

“In the course of an atom’s development, there comes a stage when the required number of particles for its constitution are all integrated, and at that point, it becomes constitutionally complete. Constitutional completeness signifies satisfaction within, by, and for that constitution. This is the immortality of the result, and the attainment of sentient status.” - SB, p. 59

This development occurs within the eternal law of coexistence, meaning the potential for sentience is already inherent in existence:

“All types of atoms, including constitutionally complete ones, are eternally present through the natural law of coexistence in existence.” - SB, p. 59

Question	Madhyasth Darshan answer
Did existence begin?	No. Existence (<i>astitva</i>) is eternally present coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>).
Did units begin from non-existence?	No. “That which was not, does not come into existence” (<i>abhava</i>).
Do bodies begin and end?	Yes. Birth and death are events at the level of body (<i>shareer</i>) and association.
Does <i>jeevan</i> begin at birth?	No. <i>Jeevan</i> is immortal; birth and death are occurrences.
Does sentient status have a developmental account?	Yes. Constitutional completeness (<i>gathanpurnata</i>) is described as attainment of sentient status (<i>chaitanya</i>), but within eternal coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>), not as creation from nothing.

1.5 The Perpetual World: *Brahma Satya Hai, Jagat Satat Hai*

MVD compresses the coexistential ontology into one line:

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” - MVD, p. 13

This is not a minor rhetorical flourish. It states a metaphysical commitment: Brahma (Omnipresence / *satta*) and the world of units (*ikai*) are both real, neither cancelled by the other. If the world is perpetual (*satat*), then matter (*jada*) is not ultimately negated, relationships (*sambandh*) are not merely provisional, and humane conduct (*manaviya aacharan*) is not merely preparatory to escape from the world.

Madhyasth Darshan therefore rejects two reductions that would split this inseparable whole:

1. **Material reductionism:** only physicochemical matter (*jada*) exists.
2. **World-negating spiritualism:** only the formless ground (*satta*) is finally real and the world is diminished to mere appearance (*mithya*).

Its positive claim is: **Brahma is real, the world is real, and their inseparable presentness is coexistence (*saha-astitva*).**

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

The claim in one sentence: Existence in the strictest sense is Brahman alone, one without a second; the world of names, forms, bodies, and relations is *mithya*, a dependent appearance, and the true Self is not born or destroyed because it is identical with Brahman.

2.1 Existence Alone, One Without a Second

The Chandogya Upanishad gives the classical Advaita starting point:

“In the beginning this was Existence alone, One only, without a second.”
- CU 6.2.1

Shankara’s commentary glosses *sat* as:

“mere Existence, a thing that is subtle, without distinction, all pervasive, one, taintless, partless, consciousness” - CU 6.2.1, Shankara commentary

The text also rejects the idea that existence comes from non-existence:

“By what logic can existence verily come out of non-existence? But surely, o good looking one, in the beginning all this was Existence, One only, without a second.” - CU 6.2.2

Advaita thus denies that absolute existence could arise from non-existence. The further Advaita question is what the many things of the world amount to within that one Existence.

2.2 Sat-Chit-Ananda: Being, Consciousness, Bliss

A second classical Advaita formulation names existence not only as *sat* — bare being — but as **Sat-Chit-Ananda**: being-consciousness-bliss. This is not three separate realities added together. In Advaita, Brahman / the true Self is one partless reality whose nature is expressed in these three inseparable names.

The Taittiriya Upanishad gives an early root of the formula when it defines Brahman as:

“Brahman is Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity.” - TU 2.1.1

Shankara’s tradition reads *satyam* as being or reality, *jnanam* as consciousness, and *anantam* as the infinite — not finite, not bounded by name and form. The *anandamaya* sheath passage in the same Upanishad (TU 2.5) then leads the seeker beyond even bliss as a sheath to the Self beyond all coverings. Shankara states the mature Advaita formula in the *Vivekachudamani*:

I am of the nature of Existence-Consciousness-Bliss. I am the very Self, indestructible and ever unchanging.

This is the meditative rendering of Shankara’s teaching at *Vivekachudamani* v. 152 (trans. Swami Madhavananda):

“By that alone he comes to know his own Self as Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute and becomes happy.” - VC, v. 152

The same triad appears again at v. 217, where the Self “makes Itself felt as the Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute” within the heart. Shankara’s Sanskrit idiom is *sat-cit-ananda*; the published translation uses “Existence-Knowledge-Bliss” for the same formula.

In this scheme:

1. **Sat** — Existence is not a property Brahman happens to have; Brahman *is* existence. To exist in the absolute sense is to be Brahman.
2. **Chit** — Consciousness is not a function of mind or brain; it is the very nature of reality and Self. The seer, seeing, and light of awareness are finally one.
3. **Ananda** — Bliss is not mere pleasure or emotion; it is the intrinsic fullness of the Self free from lack, fear, and dependence on objects.

So for Advaita, the question “what is existence?” receives a concentrated answer: **existence is the one reality that is being, consciousness, and bliss without a second.** The world of bodies, minds, and relations does not add a second kind of existence; it appears within, and is finally sublated by, that one.

2.3 What Exists in Advaita?

Advaita’s strict answer is: **Brahman alone exists absolutely.** The world is not sheer nothing, but it is not absolutely real either. It is *mithya*: dependent appearance.

Shankara, in the *Vivekachudamani*, states the discrimination between real and unreal:

“A firm conviction of the mind to the effect that Brahman is real and the universe unreal, is designated as discrimination (Viveka) between the Real and the unreal.” - VC, v. 20 (trans. Swami Madhavananda)

On the identity of *jiva* and Brahman he teaches:

“The individual soul is itself and directly the Supreme Brahman, and nothing else.” - VC, v. 216

It also gives the clay-pot analogy:

“All modifications of clay, such as the jar, which are always accepted by the mind as real, are (in reality) nothing but clay. Similarly, this entire universe which is produced from the real Brahman, is Brahman Itself and nothing but That.” - VC, v. 251

For Advaita, then, the question “what exists?” has two levels:

Level	What exists?	Status of world
Empirical (<i>vyavahara</i>)	Bodies, minds, causes, effects, duties, scriptures, practices	Operationally valid
Absolute (<i>paramartha</i>)	Brahman alone	World is <i>mithya</i> , dependent appearance

2.4 Does What Exists Begin?

For Advaita, Brahman does not begin. It is beginningless, partless, actionless, and non-dual. The universe as name-form appearance has origination at the empirical level, but its material

and ultimate truth is Brahman. Creation is therefore not absolute production out of nothing; it is manifestation or appearance of names and forms on the basis of Brahman.

Shankara expresses the Self's changelessness repeatedly in the *Vivekachudamani*:

“Brahman is Existence, Knowledge, Infinity, pure, supreme, self-existent, eternal and indivisible Bliss, not different (in reality) from the individual soul, and devoid of interior or exterior.” - VC, v. 225

“The Supreme Brahman is, like the sky, pure, absolute, infinite, motionless and changeless, devoid of interior or exterior, the One Existence, without a second, and one's own Self.” - VC, v. 393

3. Modern Philosophical Approaches

The claim in one sentence: Modern philosophy has no single answer to existence; it usually begins from the physical universe and public evidence, but contemporary debates about consciousness, selfhood, and experience show that “what exists” remains contested.

The references available here are mainly modern philosophy of mind and cognitive science, not cosmology. Therefore this section does not claim to settle whether the physical universe began in a Big Bang, or whether spacetime is fundamental. It compares Madhyasth Darshan with modern approaches to **what kinds of things must be admitted as real**.

3.1 Standard Physicalism: Concrete Reality is Physical

Physicalism is the dominant modern background view. Strawson defines it plainly:

“I take physicalism to be the view that every real, concrete phenomenon in the universe is...physical.” - Strawson 2006, p. 2

On this approach, what exists are physical things, events, fields, organisms, brains, bodies, and their processes. Minds and selves are not separate substances. They are functions, organizations, models, or processes of physical systems.

Modern self-model theories follow this line. Limanowski and Blankenburg describe minimal selfhood as emerging from embodied self-modeling:

“minimal selfhood emerges as the result” - Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013, p. 1

They further summarize free-energy accounts as explaining selfhood through embodied predictive models:

“In one sentence, these accounts propose to ‘understand the elusive sense of minimal self in terms of having internal models that successfully predict or match the sensory consequences of our own movement, our intentions in action, and our sensory input’.” - Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013, p. 3

This is almost the opposite of Madhyasth Darshan’s *jeevan* ontology. For Madhyasth Darshan, the self is a real sentient unit using the body. For the self-model approach, the self is a model generated by embodied prediction and integration.

3.2 The Hard Problem: Experience Resists Reduction

Physicalism faces the problem of experience. Chalmers formulates it as the “hard problem”:

“The really hard problem of consciousness is the problem of experience. When we think and perceive, there is a whirl of information-processing, but there is also a subjective aspect.” - Chalmers 1995, p. 3

He adds:

“It is widely agreed that experience arises from a physical basis, but we have no good explanation of why and how it so arises. Why should physical processing give rise to a rich inner life at all?” - Chalmers 1995, p. 3

Nagel makes the same difficulty vivid through the bat example, grounding it in his canonical formulation of what consciousness is:

“the fact that an organism has conscious experience at all means, basically, that there is something it is like to be that organism.” - Nagel 1974, p. 1

For Madhyasth Darshan, this is not merely a gap in explanation. It is evidence that the ontology of body alone is incomplete. The modern physicalist may reply that an explanatory gap is not proof of *jeevan*. This is the central disagreement.

3.3 Panpsychist Physicalism: Experience as Fundamental

Strawson accepts physicalism but argues that a realistic physicalism cannot deny experience. He writes:

“Full recognition of the reality of experience, then, is the obligatory starting point for any remotely realistic version of physicalism.” - *Strawson 2006, p. 2*

He then argues that experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential:

“Experiential phenomena cannot be emergent from wholly non-experiential phenomena.” - *Strawson 2006, p. 12*

And concludes:

“Real physicalism, realistic physicalism, entails panpsychism.” - *Strawson 2006, p. 12*

This comes closer to Madhyasth Darshan than reductive physicalism does, because both refuse the idea that sentience simply appears from wholly non-sentient being. But the agreement is limited.

Madhyasth Darshan does **not** say every particle is a subject of experience. It says sentience is the status of constitutionally complete atoms, while other atoms remain engaged in physical and chemical activity. Strawson’s panpsychism and Madhyasth Darshan both challenge dead-matter reductionism, but they do so with different metaphysical structures.

3.4 Illusionism: Phenomenal Consciousness as Misdescription

Illusionism goes in the opposite direction. Frankish writes:

“Another approach, which holds that phenomenal consciousness is an illusion and aims to explain why it seems to exist.” - *Frankish 2016, p. 1*

He clarifies that illusionists deny phenomenal properties, not all consciousness-talk:

“illusionists deny the existence of phenomenal consciousness properly so-called, but do not deny the existence of a form of consciousness” - *Frankish 2016, p. 8*

Madhyasth Darshan would regard this as another form of reductionism. It treats lived experience, valuation, aspiration, and realization as activities of *jeevan*, not as illusions produced by a brain-model. But illusionism is philosophically important because it shows how far modern naturalism may go to preserve a physicalist ontology.

3.5 Physical Cosmology: Does the Physical Universe Have a Beginning?

To evaluate the question “does the thing that exists begin at some time?” from a modern scientific standpoint, we must look beyond philosophy of mind to physical cosmology. The standard cosmological model (based on General Relativity) suggests that the observable universe—including space and time itself—had a beginning at a singularity approximately 13.8 billion years ago. If taken as the absolute origin of all physical reality, this singularity would challenge the view that existence is beginningless.

However, contemporary theoretical physics and quantum cosmology suggest that the Big Bang may not have been the absolute beginning of reality. Because General Relativity breaks down at the Planck scale, physicists have proposed several non-singular models:

1. **Loop Quantum Cosmology (Big Bounce):** In this model, quantum gravity effects prevent the universe from collapsing into a singularity of infinite density. Instead, when the universe contracts to a critical density, it “bounces” back. This implies our Big Bang was a transition from a prior collapsing universe, extending time infinitely into the past.
2. **Conformal Cyclic Cosmology (CCC):** Proposed by Roger Penrose, this model suggests the universe progresses through an infinite sequence of cycles (aeons). The extreme expansion of one aeon eventually becomes mathematically identical to the hot, dense beginning of the next.
3. **Eternal Inflation and the Multiverse:** In inflationary cosmology, our local universe is one of many “bubble universes” spawned within a wider, eternally inflating space. While our bubble had a beginning, the overarching multiverse vacuum is eternal.

Conceptual Comparison: These models suggest that while particular configurations (like our local bubble universe, stars, and bodies) have clear beginnings and ends, the underlying physical substrate (space, energy fields, or quantum vacuum) is beginningless. This conceptualization aligns with Madhyasth Darshan’s claim that nature (*prakriti*) is perpetual (*satat*), meaning that physical units (*jada ikai*) and their all-pervasive ground (*satta*) are eternally present, even though their specific physical forms and associations are in constant flux.

3.6 Does What Exists Begin in Modern Philosophy and Science?

The modern references used here do not supply a single answer. A cautious comparison is:

1. **Physicalism & Cosmology:** Particular organisms, brains, stars, and local universes begin and end; however, fundamental physics and quantum cosmology increasingly point toward a beginningless physical substrate (fields, energy, or cyclic space).
2. **Self-model theories:** The self begins developmentally as embodied modeling capacities arise; there is no eternal individual self.
3. **Panpsychism:** Experientiality may belong to fundamental physical reality; particular minds still depend on organization.

4. **Illusionism:** Phenomenal consciousness never begins, because phenomenal consciousness in the realist sense does not exist; what begins are quasi-phenomenal representational and cognitive states.

Compared with all of these, Madhyasth Darshan makes a stronger metaphysical claim: existence as coexistence (*saha-astitva*) is eternal, units (*ikai*) are not annihilated, and *jeevan* is immortal. This eternalism is consistent with the conservation principles of physics and beginningless cosmological models, though its claims about individual immortality (*jeevan*) and sentient completeness (*gathanpurnata*) remain distinct metaphysical assertions that cannot be validated by current physical science alone.

4. Comparison

Sections 1–3 state each position on its own terms. This section gathers the contrasts in one place.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern physicalist approaches
What is existence?	Eternally present coexistence: Omnipresence plus all units saturated in it.	Brahman / Existence alone, one without a second.	Concrete physical reality, studied empirically.
What exists absolutely?	Omnipresence and real units, sentient and insentient.	Brahman alone.	Usually the physical; experience disputed.
Is the world real?	Yes. “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.”	Empirically valid but ultimately <i>mithya</i> .	Yes, as physical reality.
Does existence begin?	No. What exists does not come from non-existence.	Brahman does not begin.	Particular systems begin and end; cosmology unsettled.
Does the individual self begin?	<i>Jeevan</i> does not begin at birth or die with the body.	<i>Jiva</i> is ultimately Brahman; individuality is ignorance.	Self develops as biological/cognitive process.
What changes?	Forms, bodies, configurations, awakening.	Names and forms appear and are sublated; Brahman is changeless.	Physical and mental configurations change.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern physicalist approaches
Method of knowing	Study, realization, behavior, experiment.	Scripture, reasoning, contemplative discrimination.	Observation, modelling, public evidence.
Ethical consequence	Humane conduct evidences understanding of coexistence.	Ethics prepares the mind for liberation.	Ethics via naturalism, social theory, or normative philosophy.

Agreement

Madhyasth Darshan and Advaita share one deep commitment: **existence does not arise from non-existence**. Modern physicalism is a weaker third party. It does not settle whether the totality of being had a beginning—that belongs to cosmology—and the philosophy-of-mind sources used here only say that minds arise within already-existing physical processes.

Disagreement

The decisive issue is **the status of plurality**.

- **Advaita** gives final reality to the One; the world is *mithya*, and liberation is recognising “I am Brahman.”
- **Physicalism** gives final reality to the physical; self and consciousness are usually process, model, or illusion.
- **Madhyasth Darshan** gives reality to both Omnipresence and the many: the world is perpetual, units are real, and coexistence is evidenced in conduct.

Advaita’s **Sat-Chit-Ananda** and Madhyasth Darshan’s **coexistence** can sound like the same answer to “what is existence?” Both speak of being, consciousness, and fulfilment. The contrast is not over whether those words appear, but over **what they name and whether the world survives them**.

For Advaita, *sat*, *chit*, and *ananda* are three names for **one** ultimate reality — Brahman / the true Self — without a second. Existence **is** that single being-consciousness-bliss; the world of units, bodies, and relations is finally *mithya*, resolved into that identity. Liberation is recognising “I am Brahman.” In this non-dual identity, the absolute has no internal distinctions (*svagata-bheda*), external distinctions (*vijatiya-bheda*), or generic distinctions (*sajatiya-bheda*).

For Madhyasth Darshan, the same vocabulary is **distributed across coexistence (saha-astitva)**, not compressed into one subject.

- **Being (Sat):** Rather than being a single undifferentiated reality, beingness (*astitva*) is the inseparable presence of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and countless active units (*ikai*). The world of units is perpetual and real.
- **Consciousness (Chit):** Consciousness has a dual structure. Pervasive Space (*satta* / *vyapak*) is “Knowledge itself” (*gyan*) — the all-pervasive, transparent energy ground. However, subjective sentience (*chaitanya*) — the capacity to know, desire, and experience — belongs exclusively to the constitutionally complete unit (*jeevan*). Space does not act as a knower; *jeevan* is the knower that realizes Satta.
- **Bliss (Ananda):** Bliss is not a static quality of the formless ground, but the state of realization and harmony (*anubhuti*) within the awakened *jeevan* when its inner faculties (mind, intellect, soul) are aligned in coexistence, expressing itself as humane conduct.

The table below contrasts this structural difference:

Concept	Advaita Vedanta (Unified Non-Dualism)	Madhyasth Darshan (Distributed Coexistence)
Sat (Being)	Brahman alone is Sat. The world is a dependent appearance (<i>mithya</i>) that is ultimately negated.	Beingness (<i>astitva</i>) is coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>) of formless space (<i>satta</i>) and countless real units (<i>ikai</i>).
Chit (Consciousness)	Pure Awareness itself, identical to the inner Self (<i>Atman</i>). The world of names and forms is inert.	Space (<i>satta</i>) is pervasive knowledge/energy, but active sentience (<i>chaitanya</i>) belongs to the <i>jeevan</i> unit.
Ananda (Bliss)	The intrinsic nature of Brahman. Sensory joy is merely a distorted reflection of Brahman-bliss.	Bliss (<i>ananda</i>) is the harmony realized <i>within</i> the awakened <i>jeevan</i> , manifested as humane conduct.

Modern philosophy has no parallel formula. It may treat experience as physical, fundamental, or illusory, but it does not name existence as Sat-Chit-Ananda or as coexistence.

Madhyasth Darshan is therefore not simply “another non-dualism.” It affirms inseparable togetherness without erasing the many.

5. Critical Review

5.1 Strengths of the Madhyasth Darshan Position

- 1. It answers the three questions directly.** Existence is beingness and indestructibility in the form of coexistence. What exists is Omnipresence and all units. What exists does not begin from non-being.
- 2. It avoids world-negation.** By saying “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual,” it preserves the reality of nature, society, relationship, production, and ethical responsibility.
- 3. It avoids simple material reductionism.** It refuses to treat consciousness, value, and selfhood as mere byproducts of body-chemistry.
- 4. It links ontology and conduct.** If existence is coexistence, then human fulfillment must be evidenced as coexistence in behavior, not merely claimed as belief.
- 5. It gives a conservation-based metaphysics.** The principle that nothing existent is annihilated gives internal coherence to its account of body, *jeevan*, death, transformation, and development.

5.2 Open Problems for Madhyasth Darshan

- 1. The leap from indestructibility to *jeevan* is not publicly established.** The general claim that reality is not annihilated does not by itself prove that a distinct sentient unit survives bodily death.
- 2. Constitutional completeness is not yet scientifically operational.** The claim that an atom becomes constitutionally complete and thereby attains sentient status is central to the darshan, but it is not presently measurable in physics or chemistry.
- 3. The interaction between *jeevan* and body needs clearer articulation.** If *jeevan* drives the body, modern readers will ask how intention becomes neural and muscular activity.
- 4. The vocabulary of Omnipresence risks ambiguity.** MVD and SB use names such as Space, Knowledge, Consciousness, Omnipotence, Brahma, God, and Absolute Energy. A rigorous presentation must prevent readers from collapsing these into Advaita Brahman, theistic God, physical energy, or psychological consciousness.
- 5. The evidence standard differs from modern science.** Madhyasth Darshan cites realization, behavior, and experiment. Modern science will accept public behavioral evidence but will not accept private realization as establishing ontology without independent testability.
- 6. The “nothing is annihilated” principle and modern physics.** The conservation ontology in Madhyasth Darshan—illustrated by the idea that a substance never gets annihilated—seems at first glance to align with classical conservation of mass and energy. However, modern physics describes processes that look like creation and annihilation: particle-antiparticle annihilation (where an electron and positron collide and disappear into photons) and pair creation (where particles appear out of high-energy light). Quantum field theory (QFT) explains that these are not passages into or out of absolute non-being. Rather,

particles are localized excitations of underlying, all-pervasive fields (such as the electron or electromagnetic fields) which are themselves conserved and beginningless. Annihilation is simply the transformation of one type of field excitation (matter) into another (radiation/photons), governed by strict conservation laws of energy-momentum, charge, and other invariants. Thus, modern physics supports the conceptual claim that fundamental reality (*vastu*) is never annihilated, only its configurations (*roop*) are transformed. The paper makes this alignment explicit, showing how the “nothing is annihilated” principle maps to conserved quantities in physics.

5.3 Strengths and Limits of Advaita

Advaita has a powerful answer to non-being: existence cannot arise from non-existence. It also gives a rigorous first-person method of discriminating the seer from the seen. Its weakness, from the Madhyasth perspective, is that it makes the world dependent appearance. That makes it harder to ground the ultimate reality of relationships, nature, society, and humane conduct.

Advaita may reply that ethics and compassion remain valid at the empirical level, and that realization of non-duality deepens rather than weakens them. Madhyasth Darshan’s counter-reply is that an ontology which makes the world *mithya* cannot give the world the same final weight as coexistence gives it.

5.4 Strengths and Limits of Modern Approaches

Modern approaches are strongest where Madhyasth Darshan is weakest: public evidence, empirical correction, cognitive modelling, and precise mechanisms. Self-model theory can explain many features of embodied selfhood without positing an eternal *jeevan*. Illusionism shows how a naturalist can reinterpret even the seeming obviousness of phenomenal consciousness.

But modern philosophy is not unified. Chalmers and Nagel show that subjective experience remains difficult to reduce. Strawson shows that some physicalists move toward panpsychism rather than eliminativism. These debates make it inaccurate to say “modern philosophy has proved the self is only the brain.” It has not. It has, however, set a high evidential burden for any claim of an immortal sentient unit.

Two Western positions not engaged here would sharpen the comparison further. Whitehead’s process philosophy is arguably the closest Western analogue to Madhyasth Darshan: it treats plurality as real, relations as ontologically fundamental, and reality as perpetual becoming rather than static substance. Neutral monism (Russell, Mach) resembles the account of Omnipresence as a reality that is neither mind nor matter but the common ground of both. Engaging these would let Madhyasth Darshan be compared with traditions that share its refusal of both world-negation and matter-only reductionism, rather than only with philosophy of mind that mostly does not.

6. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan's answer to the paper's three questions is exact:

1. **What is Existence?** Existence is eternally present coexistence: formless Omnipresence and formful units inseparably present.
2. **What exists?** Omnipresence exists; countless sentient and insentient units exist; their form, properties, nature, dharma, mutuality, and orderliness exist.
3. **Does the thing that exists begin at some time?** No. That which exists does not come from non-existence and is not annihilated. Bodies and configurations begin and end; existence and existent realities persist through transformation.

Its most distinctive formulation is:

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” - *MVD*, p. 13

This single line marks the difference from Advaita and modern physicalism at once. Against Advaita, it says the world is not *mithya*. Against physicalism, it says existence is not merely physicochemical matter. Against both, it says reality is neither world-negation nor matter-only, but coexistence.

The philosophical strength of this view is that it makes the world, relationships, conduct, and ecological responsibility fully real. Its unresolved challenge is evidential: to persuade readers outside the tradition, it must clarify how claims such as *jeevan*, constitutional completeness, and post-death continuity can be studied, tested, or at least responsibly distinguished from metaphysical assertion.

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